
THE COMPLETE SYSTEM

Lean for *Good.*

Everything I teach, in one document. No pills, no medications, no complicated BS. Cut your calories, follow the plan, and get lean.

500–800

DAILY CALORIE DEFICIT

1g / lb

PROTEIN EVERY DAY

100%

NATURAL. NO SHORTCUTS

3–6 *mo*

TO THE PHYSIQUE YOU
WANT

Stop *overcomplicating* it

You don't need the perfect workout routine. You don't need the perfect cardio regimen. You don't need another supplement stack. You need to cut your calories. That's the entire foundation of this plan. Everything else in these pages exists to make that one thing easier.

THE THREE LAWS EVERYTHING ELSE SITS ON

01

Diet is 80% of this

Fix your diet and you will lose weight by default. The gym keeps your muscle. Cardio helps your health. But the deficit does the fat loss.

02

Get lean first. Bulk later.

Stop telling yourself you need to "get big" first. You're coping. Get to 10–12% body fat, then bulk. Your body partitions nutrients better when you're lean, so you'll build muscle way easier anyway.

03

Aggressive beats slow and steady

Fast results keep you on track because you can see it working. And if you slip up for a day or two, an aggressive cut means you don't erase three weeks of progress. Keep exercise minimal, cut calories hard, watch the fat come off.

"The physique you want is only three to six months away for most of you. Just lock in."

SETH BURKHART • JULY 2026

The *math*

Five minutes of setup. Do this once, then never think about it again.

01 Find your maintenance calories

Go online and search "calorie maintenance calculator." Enter your stats. That number is what your body burns in a day.

02 Subtract 500–800

That's your daily calorie target. We're going aggressive, remember. 500 if you have a little to lose, up to 800 if you have a lot.

03 Set your macros

Calories get you lighter. Macros make you look good. Hit these every day:

— PROTEIN

1g / lb bodyweight

Non-negotiable. This is what keeps muscle on your frame while the fat comes off.

— FAT

0.3g / lb bodyweight

You're natural. Your body makes testosterone from fat. Don't cut it out.

— CARBS

Rest of calories

Carbs are the lever. Down on a cut, up on a bulk, shifting with your training days.

— THE FRAMEWORK THAT EXPLAINS EVERYTHING

Calories determine your weight loss. **Macronutrients** determine how you look. **Micronutrients** determine how you feel. You could lose weight eating donuts in a deficit, but you'd end up skinny fat and feeling terrible. That's why all three layers matter. And get 35–40g of fiber a day from fruits and vegetables — it keeps you full while you're in the deficit.

"Track your calories for six months to a year so you know how much is in every kind of food you eat. Then from then on, you'll just know, and you'll never have to track another calorie again."

SETH BURKHART • ON TRACKING

Whole foods *only*

If the food wasn't around 100 years ago, why are you eating it today? Cut processed food completely. Eat one-ingredient foods. It is so simple to eat clean.

MACRO	EAT THIS	NOTES
PROTEIN	Eggs · 90/10 ground beef · steak · chicken breast & thighs · Greek yogurt	Protein powder is a tool, not a main source. Eat real food first.
CARBS	Potatoes · berries · fruit · raw honey · sourdough · vegetables	Potatoes over rice. Rice digests fast and spikes hunger. Potatoes keep you full for way longer.
FATS	Avocado · eggs · butter	Keep it simple. Your grandparents lived off butter. It's fine.

THE EATING STRUCTURE

- **Nothing before 12 PM.** Eating window is 12–8 PM. You still get all your calories, protein, and fiber inside it.
- **2–3 meals. Zero snacks.** Solid meals with all three macros digest slowly and keep you full. Snacking is how people lose track of their deficit.
- **Same meals every day.** Find a few macro-friendly meals you enjoy and spam them. Every shredded guy you know does this.

A DAY OF EATING

AM	Water + pink Himalayan salt, black coffee, creatine. No food.
12 PM	Meal 1: protein + fats + carbs
7–8 PM	Meal 2: protein + fats + carbs
All day	Gallon of water with electrolytes

"Seth, what do I eat? You eat whole foods. You eat one ingredient foods. Eggs, red meat, chicken. Fruits, vegetables, rice, potatoes, honey. Avocados, eggs, butter. You get the point."

SETH BURKHART · ON FOOD CHOICES

Hunger means it's *working*

Next time you get hungry, don't eat anything. That feeling is your body telling you it's about to use fat for energy. You're going to be hungry sometimes. It's temporary. You're not going to die. Sit in it a little longer, and use the tools below.

"You need to be a little bit uncomfortable and sit in the hunger a little longer. You can still get your calories for the day. You can still get your protein. You're not gonna die. That's literally the whole point."

SETH BURKHART · ON HUNGER

THE CRAVING KILLERS

- **A gallon of water a day.** Put pink Himalayan salt in it. Four 32 oz bottles. This alone kills most of your hunger.
- **Diet soda.** Coke Zero scratches the sugar itch for zero calories. Total cheat code.
- **Electrolytes.** Coconut water or salt water when a craving hits. Watch it disappear.
- **Go train or walk.** Sounds backwards, but working out kills hunger. I swear this works.
- **Black coffee.** Morning tool. Extends your fast, curbs your appetite, gives you energy.
- **Get sunlight.** You don't only get energy from food. Sun and electrolytes carry you further than you think.

IF YOU BINGE - THE PROTOCOL

The hardest part isn't getting back on the horse. It's forgiving yourself. I used to hit McDonald's at midnight and wake up disgusted with myself. Forgive yourself, move on, and get back to the plan at the next meal. That old version of you doesn't exist anymore. One bad night doesn't erase two good weeks. On an aggressive cut, it can't.

Insulin & carb *timing*

This is the reason most people can't stay in a deficit. You spike your insulin at 9 AM with a carb-heavy breakfast, it spikes your hunger, you graze all day, and the deficit is gone. Control the spike and the deficit gets easy.

"You can't lose weight because you keep spiking your insulin, which is spiking your hunger, which is making you bingy, which is making you not be in a calorie deficit."

SETH BURKHART · ON INSULIN

THE RULES

01 No carbs early in the day

Save them for later. Mornings are salt, coffee, water, creatine. Your body stays in fat-burning mode and your hunger stays quiet.

02 Time your spikes around training

The two windows where an insulin spike works for you: right before your workout for energy, and right after to refill glycogen. If you train in the morning, go ahead and spike it. If you're not training, why are you spiking insulin at 9 AM?

03 Cycle your carbs with your training days

Why would you eat the same carbs on a rest day as on leg day? Training day: more carbs. Rest day: fewer. Your body never adapts, your metabolism stays guessing, and you keep burning fat.

04 Fasted training is a tool, not a rule

Ate a big carb dinner? Train fasted in the morning, you're running on stored glycogen. Stomach empty and sluggish? Eat some fast carbs first, honey or sourdough. Evening workout? Eat before it. Either way, the deficit is what decides your results.

Lift heavy. Keep it *simple*.

The gym's job on a cut is to keep the muscle on your frame so you don't end up skinny fat. That takes way less than you think. More is not better here. Extra volume just spikes your hunger and wrecks your deficit.

FREQUENCY

3–4 days / week

3 days: full body. 4 days: upper / lower. Honestly, your split doesn't matter. Pick one and show up.

INTENSITY

4–8 reps, heavy

Don't drop the weight because you're cutting. Heavy lifting is the signal that tells your body to keep its muscle.

- **Progressive overload is the whole game.** Pick a lift you like for each muscle group, get strong at it over time, add weight and reps. Stop hunting for the perfect exercise.
- **Don't skip legs.** Legs spike your growth hormone and testosterone and speed up everything, including fat loss. If you're skipping legs, what are you doing?
- **Abs, the simple way.** Weighted decline sit-ups and hanging leg raises. Two sets of each, every other day, after your workout. No 10-minute ab routines. Nobody sticks to those.
- **Worried about losing muscle? Don't be.** Hit your protein, lift heavy, and even if you lose a little, it's back within two weeks of returning to maintenance.

PRE-WORKOUT, IF YOU WANT A GREAT SESSION

Three things: **electrolytes, carbs, caffeine**. Combine all three and watch what happens to your lifts.

"Stop going to the gym five days a week and running all this crazy cardio. Less is more when you're trying to lose a bunch of weight. Do the minimum, cut your calories, and you will lose weight."

SETH BURKHART • ON OVERTRAINING

Steps, cardio, *sleep*

— STEPS

10K / day

Non-negotiable. No exceptions. Just leave your house. If you say you don't have time, you're lying.

— CARDIO

3× 20–30 min / week

Zone 2, low intensity. Target 250–300 calories per session. After lifting, or fasted in the morning.

— SLEEP

7–8 hours / night

Under-sleep and your body literally stores fat instead of burning it. Studies back this up.

— THE EXACT CARDIO PROTOCOL I USE AND GIVE MY CLIENTS

Incline treadmill. **12–15% incline, 3.0 mph, 20–30 minutes.** That's it. You don't need 8-mile runs or an hour on the treadmill. And you're chilling the whole time.

STEPS ARE NOT CARDIO

Steps burn calories, and yes, you could get lean on steps alone. But cardio means raising your heart rate, and the health benefits come from that. Do both: steps every day for the burn, three short zone-2 sessions a week for your heart.

THE RECOVERY STACK

- **Magnesium** before bed if you have trouble sleeping.
- **Creatine 10g**, every morning, empty stomach. Not for size. For your brain. Mental sharpness, focus, and it can even offset a rough night of sleep.
- **No food 2 hours before bed.** No phone either. Both wreck sleep quality.
- **Electrolytes daily.** Energy, better pumps, fewer cravings.

"The best way to start your morning every single day: salt, coffee, and creatine. I haven't eaten breakfast in a long time. This is how I stay lean."

SETH BURKHART • MORNING ROUTINE

The mental *game*

The hardest part of losing weight is the psychological battle. You're fighting yourself every day, because you're changing a lifestyle you're used to. Here's how you win it.

"It's really hard to get in shape. It's really easy to stay in shape. Lock in for three to six months, get the physique, and then it's actually crazy how it works. You won't understand until you get there."

SETH BURKHART · HARD TO GET, EASY TO KEEP

01 Earn the 80/20

The 80/20 diet approach is garbage at first. Every guy with abs went through a stretch of being locked in and perfect. Go perfect for a couple months, change your body physiologically, then you've earned the right to cheat sometimes. You can't start at 80/20.

02 Take a mirror photo every morning

Uncomfortable? That's the point. If a week goes by with no change, that wakes you up. If you look better than last month, you're on track. Compare yourself to yourself. Nobody else.

03 Do it for you

There will always be someone leaner, more jacked, better looking. It's you against you. Better than a month ago? You're chilling.

04 Know what you're actually buying

When you get lean, you don't even know what your face looks like yet. Jawline, mental clarity, less inflammation, clothes fit right. Your physique is the fit. A plain black tee will look better on you than designer does on anyone else. And the discipline spills into everything: money, business, relationships.

The full *protocol*

The whole plan on one page. Do this daily until the mirror tells you to stop.

EVERY DAY

- ☐ **Calories:** maintenance –500 to –800
- ☐ **Protein:** 1g per lb bodyweight
- ☐ **Fat:** 0.3g per lb · **Fiber:** 35–40g
- ☐ **Eating window:** 12–8 PM, 2–3 meals, zero snacks
- ☐ **Morning:** salt water, black coffee, creatine 10g
- ☐ **Water:** a gallon, with electrolytes
- ☐ **Steps:** 10,000, non-negotiable
- ☐ **Sleep:** 7–8 hours
- ☐ **Mirror photo** every morning

EVERY WEEK

- ☐ **Lift 3–4 days:** full body ×3 or upper/lower ×4
- ☐ **Heavy, 4–8 reps,** progressive overload
- ☐ **Never skip legs**
- ☐ **Ab:** weighted decline sit-ups + hanging leg raises, every other day
- ☐ **Cardio:** 3 sessions of incline treadmill 12–15% @ 3.0 mph, 20–30 min
- ☐ **Carbs cycle:** up on training days, down on rest days

RESULT

Run this aggressively and 15–20 lbs in a month or two is on the table. The physique you want is 3–6 months out. Then maintenance: find your new maintenance calories, eat there, done. Over one day? Eat less the next.

SITUATIONAL — A NIGHT OF DRINKING WITHOUT WRECKING THE CUT

Fast all day. Right before drinking, eat a high-protein meal with slow carbs. Drink tequila or seltzers only, and don't switch liquors. And the big one: **zero food after drinking**. Your body processes alcohol first, so anything you eat after is getting stored. Break that rule and you're cooked.

— YOU HAVE THE PLAN. NOW EXECUTE.

Let's get *lean.*

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I'll coach you through this 1-on-1 and make you your best self in 90 days.

SETH BURKHART · COACHING APPLICATION AT [SETHBURKHART.CO](https://sethburkhart.co)

This guide shares what worked for me and what I teach, for educational purposes. It is not medical advice. Talk to your doctor before starting any diet, fasting, or training protocol, especially if you have a medical condition. Results vary with consistency and starting point.